

CASE ID: 202103710002

EPISODE NAME: China Retaliates Following Xinjiang Sanctions (US) March 2021

2021/03/27 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: United States (2)

Issue: Retaliation (16)

Final Outcome: Ongoing

Summary:

On 2021/03/27, China imposed travel bans and business activity restrictions on two United States citizens after Washington sanctioned China over human rights abuses in Xinjiang on 2021/03/22. This episode is ongoing.

Narrative:

The United States imposed asset freezes on two Xinjiang senior officials on 2021/03/22, in coordination with the United Kingdom, Canada, and the European Union.¹ In response, on 2021/03/27, China announced travel bans and business activity restrictions on Chair of the United States Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF) Gayle Manchin and Vice Chair of the USCIRF Tony Perkins.²

The episode is part of a larger campaign of economic coercion that began on 2020/07/09, when the United States sanctioned three Xinjiang officials and China retaliated with sanctions on US officials.³ The US has imposed a number of additional sanctions, against which China has retaliated, both before and since 2021/03/27.^{4,5}

The sanctions are still in place, and this episode is ongoing as of 2025/12/31.

¹Verma, Pranshu. "U.S. Joins Allies to Punish Chinese Officials for Human Rights Abuses." New York Times, 22 March 2021. <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/03/22/us/politics/sanctions-china-ughurs.html>

² "Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Announces Sanctions on Relevant US and Canadian Individuals and Entity." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 27 March 2021. https://www.mfa.gov.cn/eng/xw/fyrbt/fyrbt/202405/t20240530_11349692.html

³ "China sanctions US politicians in retaliation for Uighur measures." Al Jazeera, 13 July 2020. <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2020/7/13/china-sanctions-us-politicians-in-retaliation-for-uighur-measures>

⁴ "U.S. Sanctions Tracker." Uyghur Human Rights Project, July 2025. <https://uhrp.org/sanctions-tracker/>

⁵ "China imposes sanctions on U.S. officials over Xinjiang." NBC, 21 Dec. 2021. <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/world/china-imposes-sanctions-us-officials-xinjiang-rcna9468>